

Wide Angle



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The New Year started with a whimper. For me, twice over. My Christmas bonus at office was a new PC, with a brisk new processor, plenty of RAM and a shiny new hard disk. A couple of days spent migrating my data safely over to the PC was a small price to pay for the snappy responsiveness of Firefox. Yes, it is quite a CPU hungry beast, and if you don't plan to upgrade your computer you might want to look at the Mox optimised builds (c6iv*) for the best you can get on your current hardware.

Anyway, come New Year and the hard disk went all whiny. No boot screen, no detection by BIOS, and of course no way to access my data. A call to tech support and a stand-by hard disk installation later, I found myself looking at Windows XP re-installing the second time in a week. The plan was to get back up to speed on this HDD, and when the original was replaced, the partition would be copied over with a disk image tool like Norton Ghost so I get back to work in no time. Good thing I hadn't turned in my old hard disk yet, so I had all the data back minus the days I spent un-backed up on the new PC that I hadn't expected to fail.

Crash & Learn

One needs to fall over and over before he can learn to walk—a lesson is perhaps never learned the first time around

Lesson One: You should always back up your important data. Disk failure is always a surprise. The best free tool for backup is SyncBack (c6ix). Set up multiple jobs for your

important data and rest easy.

To cut a short story shorter, a few days after I was all settled in nicely with patches up to date and all my programs and UI tweaks just the way I like them, Windows stopped booting. The replacement hard disk too was making that ominous clicking noise. I should have paid attention to the Icon of Trust numbers. My Whimper Two was because I had failed to learn Lesson One. Yet another data loss later, I was ready to try some data recovery software. R-Studio didn't quite manage to read complete files, but Easy Recovery Pro did the job with some careful guidance. It helps to remember your partition sizes as accurately as possible.

I tidied over the next week on a lovely wide-screen Compaq laptop that evoked the right kind of responses everywhere it went. But not from me, though. I was in mourning for my two lost weeks, and didn't appreciate it as much as I should have.

When my "new" hard disk arrived a week later, I was twice burnt, third time shy. It was time for some serious agni-pariksha, and PassMark BurnInTest (c6jr) was my flame thrower. The free version of this burn-in software runs for only 15 minutes at a time, but it puts all the sub-systems—hard disk included—through the wringer whenever you install a new component, or buy a new PC.

If you already have a working old hard disk you installed into your new and upgraded CPU/Motherboard, you may want to spare your hard disk the additional strain that might push it into never-never land. To burn-in just the CPU and cooling, you should either eliminate the other modules from your test configuration in PassMark BurnInTest or use a dedicated CPU testing program such as Hot CPU Tester Pro (c6iy). Do it in the summer with the case closed to stress your system to the max, but don't flame me if the PC suffers a meltdown.

Once your computer is working fine, go and download a S.M.A.R.T. monitoring tool such as ActiveSMART (c6j0) to keep an eye on your HDD's reliability. While S.M.A.R.T. monitoring might give you some warning about impending failure, nothing substitutes for a good backup plan. Lesson One is you should always backup.

All power-users have their computer environment set-up just-so, with all the myriad utilities and shortcuts correctly configured and the UI tweaked. But going through three installs of the OS amidst work deadlines does an amazing job of distilling what you do with a new PC to just the absolute essentials. Here is briefly what I ended up with on my "new" PC version 3.0.

First things first, put up the Windows Firewall and block all network services before plugging in the network cable. Yes, sad to admit, but even our local network is infested with malware and an unprotected PC (like the temporary laptop for example) is certain to catch nasty stuff like Sasser or Nimda. If you are going on the Internet unprotected, this research report (c6j2) should set you straight.

Next come the hours of Windows Update patches—painful but necessary. I use the free Avast! Antivirus and keep Spybot and AdAware handy just in case my Internet Explorer picks up something nasty. If you don't install Service Pack 2, BHODemon (c6j5) will help keep your IE cruft-free. Of course, I mostly use Firefox with a dozen extensions, so IE is not much trouble.

You could choose to install a free third-party firewall like ZoneAlarm or Kerio Personal Firewall for complete protection, but since I am behind a corporate firewall run by an admin who knows what he is doing, I don't. You should also try to not run as an Administrator-level user and RunAsAdmin (c6j6) helps there.

Customising the Windows UI is managed with a combination of MS TweakUI and Kelly's awesome registry tweaks (c6j8). SlickRun (c6jd) handles my command-line needs perfectly, and Folder Pilot (c6jc) turns Explorer into a useful tool. PopFile (c6jf) keeps my mail spam free and well categorised, but you could also try SpamBayes (c6jj).

NewsPipe (c6jk) gets me my RSS feeds right in my Outlook and is quite the run-and-forget program. If you aren't comfortable running a command-line Python script, you could give the free SharpReader (c6jl) a shot.

But if there was only one thing I could talk about this month, it would be Lesson One: backup regularly! ☑

The text in brackets should be used like so: <http://snipurl.com/text> to get the website

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